

POLITICAL AND SPIRITUAL LEADER Born 1869 Died 1948

Mahatma Gandhi

“Silent suffering... speaks with an unrivaled eloquence.” GANDHI, 1923

Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, known as Mahatma (“Grand Soul”), was born into the *vaisya* caste of Hindu society, traditionally devoted to trade. His father was prime minister of the tiny principedom of Porbandar, part of British-ruled northwestern India. Typical of privileged sectors of Indian society at that time, his life was shaped both by old Indian customs, such as an arranged marriage at an early age, and by the influence of European attitudes and ideas.

The young Gandhi was skeptical about his family’s Hindu practices, however, including the avoidance of meat, and leapt at the chance to study law in Britain. Ironically, it was as a student in London that he first encountered the *Bhagavad Gita*, a sacred Hindu text that was to influence him profoundly, and he became a committed vegetarian.

When Gandhi went to South Africa as a 23-year-old lawyer in 1893, he had

no clear purpose in life except to make money, at which he proved thoroughly successful. But the experience of the discrimination, prejudice, and mistreatment suffered by Indians in South Africa’s racially divided society drew him into political activism. He led a series of mass campaigns during which he devised the method of political struggle he called *satyagraha* (“love-force” or “truth-force,” see right). This was nonviolent civil disobedience, conceived by Gandhi as a moral and spiritual effort, seeking to bring about a change in the hearts and minds of the oppressors by



Gandhi the lawyer

As a young London-educated lawyer, Gandhi looked the epitome of a Westernized Asian. He did not adopt traditional Indian dress until 1913.

Father of the nation

In his white “dhoti,” Gandhi cut a strikingly odd figure at international political conferences. To the Indian masses, though, he seemed a reassuringly familiar type of holy man.

Handwritten letter

This letter was written in 1914, the year in which Gandhi definitively quit South Africa after two decades of campaigning for the Indians’ rights.

